

HOUSE BILL 641

By Carringer

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 9;
Title 12; Title 37; Title 39 and Title 49, relative to
funding of child advocacy centers.

WHEREAS, child advocacy centers have played a vital role for the last thirty years in the State of Tennessee to meet the needs of at-risk, neglected, and abused children; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee was the first state in the nation to require a child advocacy center in each judicial district setting the standard for the care of abused children; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee has a long history of leading the nation in the fight against child abuse and neglect; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee Code Annotated, Section 9-4-213, which was originally enacted by Chapter 988 of the Public Acts of 1988 during the 100th General Assembly, clearly outlines the requirements of a child advocacy center in order to meet funding requirements; and

WHEREAS, we, the members of the General Assembly, find that funding for all child advocacy centers' contracts has remained stagnant since 1999, resulting in increased pressure on these centers; and

WHEREAS, collectively, the child advocacy centers served over 32,000 children in 2024 with forensic interviews, victim advocacy, medical exams, and mental health clinical services; and

WHEREAS, the critical role of child advocacy centers and their staff play an integral role of bringing help, healing, and hope to thousands of child victims each year; and

WHEREAS, child advocacy centers support the work of the Department of Children's Services, local, state, and federal law enforcement agencies, and provide crucial support to the

district attorneys general in each judicial district to aid in the prosecution of crimes against children; and

WHEREAS, both the 112th and 113th General Assemblies appropriated one-time funds expecting the Department of Children's Services to increase funding to all child advocacy centers; and

WHEREAS, deaths in Tennessee from suspected abuse or neglect rose nearly thirty percent over the previous year; now, therefore,

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. This act is known and may be cited as the "Savannah Grace Copeland Act."

SECTION 2. Tennessee Code Annotated, Section 9-4-213, is amended by adding the following new subsections:

(e) In the fiscal year beginning July 1, 2026, and in subsequent fiscal years, any increase in funding for positions or office expenses for the department of children's services in child protective services must be accompanied by an increase in funding of seventy-five percent (75%) of the increase in funding to the contracts of the child advocacy center in each judicial district for the purpose of services to child victims in each fiscal year.

(f) Subject to appropriation, the department of children's services shall increase each child advocacy center contract as follows:

(1) A contract labeled as "child advocacy center" must be increased to a base of one hundred twenty-seven thousand eight hundred fifty-five dollars and ninety-eight cents (\$127,855.98); and

(2) A contract labeled as "forensic child interviewer" must be increased to a base of eighty-five thousand dollars (\$85,000) per contracted interviewer.

(g) In the fiscal year beginning July 1, 2026, and in subsequent fiscal years, funds appropriated for child advocacy centers must be allocated in accordance with the formula in subsection (e) using the contract's applicable base in subsection (f).

SECTION 3. This act is not an appropriation of funds, and funds shall not be obligated or expended pursuant to this act unless the funds are specifically appropriated by the general appropriations act.

SECTION 4. This act takes effect July 1, 2025, the public welfare requiring it, and applies to contracts entered into, renewed, or amended on or after such date.